

MARKET ENTRY GUIDE · 2026

Armenia Franchise Market Entry Guide.

A practical overview of Armenia's franchise opportunity, the master franchise and area development model, and how NorthStar Group funds and operates market entry for international brands.

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Why Armenia, right now.

Armenia sits at the crossroads of major trade routes, with membership in the Eurasian Economic Union giving Armenian-based businesses preferential trade access across the bloc, alongside deepening trade ties with the European Union. Yerevan's Zvartnots International Airport connects to 81 destinations across 34 countries.

2.9M+

Population, with over a third concentrated in Yerevan

18%

Flat corporate tax rate — one of the region's simplest regimes

2.2M+

International visitors in 2024, fueling retail and hospitality demand

3

Working languages of the modern Armenian workforce

Armenia's workforce is educated, digitally fluent, and typically operates across Armenian, Russian, and English. A global Armenian diaspora, deeply networked into business communities from Los Angeles to Dubai to Paris, adds a further layer of access and credibility for brands entering the market.

A young, urbanizing population and a fast-growing tourism sector are driving demand for the retail and hospitality brands the world already knows — exactly the conditions international franchises look for.

Master franchise vs. area development.

A **master franchise agreement** grants one partner exclusive rights to develop a brand across an entire country, including the ability to recruit and sub-license individual franchisees on the brand's behalf.

An **area development agreement** instead commits one partner to open and directly operate a set number of company-owned units within a defined territory, on a fixed timeline, without sub-licensing to other operators.

Both structures exist for the same reason: brands don't want to manage market entry unit by unit. They want one accountable, funded, local partner who owns the outcome for the entire territory. In Armenia, that partner is NorthStar Group.

Master Franchisee

Holds exclusive territory rights and can recruit sub-franchisees to operate individual units under the master agreement.

Area Developer

Commits to open and directly operate a set number of company-owned units within a defined territory and timeline.

What franchisors screen for.

Master franchise and area development agreements hand one partner exclusive control over an entire territory — so franchisors screen candidates against a defined checklist before signing anything.

Financial Capacity

The standard: Sufficient capital to fund real estate, buildout, and working capital without relying on the brand for financing.

NorthStar Group: A privately funded investment group that commits its own capital to every launch — with no capital call on the brand.

Operational & Business Experience

The standard: A demonstrated track record building, scaling, and operating businesses.

NorthStar Group: Founders who built and scaled GameBit (B2B iGaming) and theConsultancy Partners, Armenia's leading digital transformation consultancy for banks and fintech.

Local Market Knowledge

The standard: Deep, on-the-ground understanding of consumer behavior, real estate, and regulatory conditions.

NorthStar Group: Full-time, Yerevan-based operators with over a decade of local capital-raising and institutional relationships.

Long-Term Territory Commitment

The standard: A multi-year commitment to developing the full territory, not a single opportunistic unit.

NorthStar Group: Structured for exclusive, long-term agreements — incentives tied to territory-wide performance.

The full 8-point criteria checklist is available at northstararmenia.com/why-northstar.html

Where the opportunity is strongest.

Food & Beverage

Fast-casual, specialty coffee, bakery-café, and casual-dining formats have little to no international competition in Armenia today.

Retail

Armenian consumers travel and shop internationally, but many recognized retail brands have no physical presence in the country yet.

Fitness

Armenia currently has little to no representation from internationally recognized gym or boutique fitness brands.

Hospitality

Rising international arrivals are creating demand that Armenia's largely independent hospitality sector hasn't fully met.

NorthStar Group evaluates opportunities across categories beyond these four — contact us to discuss fit for your specific brand.

How a deal comes together.

- 01** **Fit & Structure**
We assess brand-market fit and agree whether a master franchise or area development structure makes the most sense for Armenia.
- 02** **Market & Investment Case**
Consumer demand, competitive mapping, and site-level economics are quantified into a full investment case before either side commits.
- 03** **Territory Agreement**
NorthStar Group signs the agreement and commits the capital required — no fundraising burden on the brand.
- 04** **Build & Launch**
Site selection, licensing, and local operations are built out to brand standard for the first location — and every one after it.
- 05** **Territory Growth**
NorthStar Group manages expansion across the agreed territory, as the single accountable partner for the life of the agreement.

Why NorthStar Group.

NorthStar Group's founders and managing partners, Aram Cherkezryan and Rafayel Mkrtchyan, are UC Berkeley alumni who spent their early careers in Silicon Valley before returning home to Armenia. There, they co-founded GameBit, a B2B iGaming platform provider specializing in Web3 and gamification, and helped attract millions of dollars of investment into the country's technology sector.

Rafayel also co-founded theConsultancy Partners, Armenia's leading digital transformation consultancy for banks, fintech, and decentralized finance.

That experience — raising capital, building institutional relationships, and operating at Silicon Valley standards from Yerevan — convinced them Armenia's next chapter of growth would come from bringing the world's most trusted consumer brands into the market, fully funded and properly run.

NorthStar Group is a privately owned investment group — independently funded and operated, with no ownership by or affiliation with the Government of Armenia or any state agency.

Ready to explore Armenia?

NorthStar Group funds and operates market entry for international brands as Armenia's master franchise and area development partner — from the first feasibility study to the grand opening, and every location after it.

If you'd like an initial view on fit, opportunity, and next steps for your brand, we're glad to talk.

LET'S TALK

Start the conversation.

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